While the Ambanis had responded with legal notices, the Adanis had stayed mostly silent. ‘Gautambhai doesn’t want to get into a blame game with anyone,’ is what I was told. Which is why I was a little surprised when in April 2014, while the campaign was picking up steam, I got a call from a London-based businessman that Gautambhai was keen to do an interview. The reason for his anxiety was obvious. Now, it was no longer Kejriwal pointing fingers; even Congress leader Rahul Gandhi was attacking the Modi–Adani ‘nexus’ on land deals.

‘Can you fly down to Ahmedabad urgently tomorrow? We want to show you our port and then do an interview,’ I was told. I said it would not be possible since I was shooting elsewhere. I sent our national bureau chief, Bhupendra Chaubey, instead. Adani vigorously defended himself in the interview, saying he had got a clean chit from the courts and had received no special favours from Modi; he insisted that he was charging the BJP’s prime ministerial candidate ‘commercial rates’ for use of the aircraft. ‘I am not the BJP’s or Modiji’s ATM machine—I have friends in all parties,’ said Gautambhai, in his heavily Gujarati-accented Hindi.

We thought we had an exclusive interview. As it turned out, Gautambhai gave nearly half a dozen interviews over the next forty-eight hours. For a self-confessed low-profile individual, the PR overdrive betrayed his anxiety at being caught in the midst of a political battle.

What is true, though, is that like all upwardly mobile business leaders, Gautambhai had struck friendships with politicians from different parties. He kept a steady equation with Congress leaders in Gujarat and beyond (a photograph of him with Robert Vadra at the Mundra port site also made it to the papers). Perhaps his closest friend in politics was NCP leader and UPA minister, Sharad Pawar. When a journalist friend went to interview Pawar once, he saw a relaxed Adani watching television with Pawar’s family in the adjoining room. The two would often dine at each other’s houses, and had reportedly even gone on a holiday together once. ‘People seem to forget that Gautambhai has as many business interests in Maharashtra as he does in Gujarat,’ an NCP leader told me. A senior Congressman from Maharashtra even claimed that the Adanis had ensured that Modi did not